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Trigonometry and Steam

The Portuguese first arrived in Bengal in 1530. They set up trading posts at Chittagong in the east and Satgaon in the west. Over time, the river near Satgaon silted up and the river port of Hooghly became the main trading hub. The port was on the Bhagirathi distributary of the Ganga—although we now usually call it the Hooghly after the old port town. By the seventeenth century, other Europeans had also set up trading posts along the river—the French at Chandannagar, the Danes at Srirampur and the Dutch at Chinsurah. The English East India Company initially had its local headquarters at Hooghly. However, it seems to have had problems with the local Mughal officials and was forced to sail downriver after a skirmish in 1686. When matters were finally settled two years later, the English sent a squadron on ships from Madras (now renamed Chennai) to re-establish their presence in Bengal. The initiative was headed by the company's chief agent Job Charnock.

THE BUILDING OF CALCUTTA

On 24 August 1690, Charnock landed at a village called Sutanuti on the east bank of the river. He had already visited the spot during the retreat two years earlier and had obviously liked it. So he decided to build the new English trading post here. It would grow into the city of Calcutta, now renamed Kolkata. This was not, however, an uninhabited landscape. There were three villages in the area—Sutanuti, Gobindapore and Kalikata The